

Topical NSAIDs: Often Overlooked, Often Effective

Gels and creams deliver pain relief with fewer systemic side effects — especially for knees and hands.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Review Board** (Multidisciplinary UK clinicians) · 2026-06-14 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Overview



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Gels and creams deliver pain relief with fewer systemic side effects — especially for knees and hands.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Arthritis UK consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



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- ****Talk to your clinician.**** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.

- **Track your symptoms.** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.
 - **Move within comfort.** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.
 - **Watch the warning signs.** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
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Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]/\(exercises/hand\)](#). 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment. 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.

Editorial standards



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This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team and reviewed by our Clinical Review Board against UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. We update content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

Many studies, including large randomised trials and systematic reviews, have looked at how well topical anti-inflammatory gels and creams work for joint pain. They generally show that these treatments can be effective for pain relief, particularly in smaller joints like those in the hands and knees. The beneficial effects are often seen within the first few weeks of consistent use.

Clinical guidelines from major UK bodies, which are based on a review of this evidence, recommend topical treatments as a good first option for localised joint pain, especially for people who might be sensitive to oral pain medications. The idea is to target the pain precisely where it hurts, reducing the overall body exposure to the medication.

While not usually as powerful as oral medications for widespread severe pain, for many people with mild to moderate joint discomfort, these topical pain relievers offer a valuable way to manage symptoms without the higher risk of internal side effects associated with pills.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Not using enough:** A pea-sized amount isn't generally sufficient; check the leaflet for guidance on how much to apply for your joint size. * **Applying too infrequently:** For best results, many topical treatments need to be applied 2-3 times a day, not just once. * **Washing it off too soon:** Give the gel or cream time to soak in properly before covering the area or washing your hands. * **Using on broken skin:** Avoid applying to cuts, scrapes, or irritated skin, as this can cause discomfort and poor absorption. * **Ignoring the instructions:** Always read the patient leaflet carefully for specific advice on how to use your particular product safely and effectively.

When to Speak to a Clinician

While topical pain relievers can be very helpful, it's important to know when your symptoms warrant a professional medical opinion. If you experience any of the following, please book an appointment with your doctor, physiotherapist or rheumatology team.

* Sudden, severe increase in pain that doesn't settle quickly. * New, significant swelling, redness, or warmth around a joint. * Difficulty moving a joint, or new weakness in a limb. * Pain that wakes you from sleep consistently or gets worse with rest. * Any signs of infection, such as fever, chills, or pus around a joint.

Frequently Asked Questions

Can I use these gels and creams long-term? For most people, topical anti-inflammatory gels and creams can be used long-term as directed, especially for managing chronic joint pain. However, it's always best to discuss ongoing use with your doctor, particularly if you have other health conditions or are taking other medications.

Do topical pain relievers interact with other medications? Because very little of the medication gets into your bloodstream when applied topically, interactions with other medications are much less common than with oral tablets. Still, if you're taking blood thinners or have kidney problems, it's wise to check with your doctor or pharmacist.

How quickly should I expect to feel better? You might start to feel some pain relief within minutes or hours of application, but it can take a few days of regular use to experience the full benefit. If you don't notice any improvement after a week of consistent use, it's a good idea to speak to a healthcare professional.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about topical nsais: often overlooked, often effective?

Short answer: Topical anti-inflammatory gels and creams can be effective for joint pain, particularly in hands and knees. They deliver pain relief locally with fewer systemic side effects than oral medications. Use them regularly, 2-3 times daily, applying enough product as advised in the leaflet. Avoid use on broken skin, and consult a doctor if pain worsens or new symptoms appear.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk